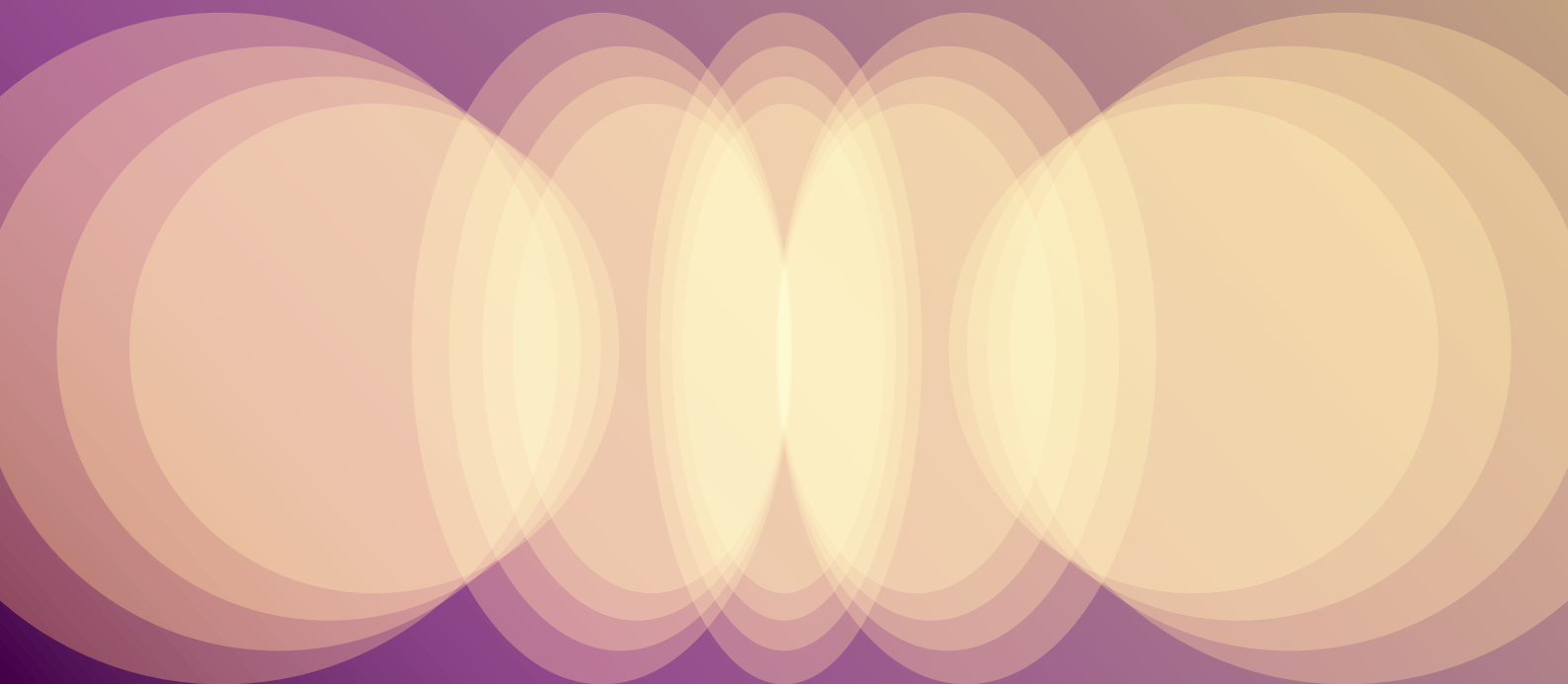


Expanding The Lens

Reflections on the South Sudan
Media Landscape



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Editorial

The South Sudanese Media Landscape – Expanding the Lens

The Access to Skills and Knowledge Network (#ASKnet) – a project focused on building local capacity through the democratization of media tools engaged many at different levels. Productions, literacy, documentation, community engagement and technical skills sharing. This project in addition to the others explores voices across practitioners, observers and wellwishers.

When we set out to compile this edition, our goal was simple yet ambitious: to capture a comprehensive snapshot of the modern media landscape in South Sudan. It is an attempt at looking at the media industry holistically. Traditional and non traditional, experiences, challenges, innovations, practice and anticipation for the future.

While hard news, radio broadcasting, and press freedom form the historic backbone of our information ecosystem, restricting "the media" to traditional newsrooms does a massive disservice to the explosion of local talent transforming the South Sudan media ecosystem. Therefore, this issue deliberately broadens the lens.

Alongside essential discussions by experts and practitioners on how communities are navigating information blind spots a spotlight on the communities in Jonglei where chiefs are an important part of the

ecosystem, citizen journalism shaping narratives, the agonizing sustainability struggles of independent newsrooms and what some owners are doing right, we intentionally highlight the vibrant, parallel world of creative media not to leave out AI that is a budding conversation around information creation, consumption and dissemination.

Implementing the #ASKnet project helped a realization that true oversight for Media development in South Sudan stretches beyond reporting the present reality around us; it is about creatively designing our future. A healthy information ecosystem where new media and creative media collate and

We invite you to read through these pages not just to analyze the challenges, but to celebrate an industry growing and the opportunities it has ahead. Taking a glimpse into the current future, we experimented with AI while exploring the potential it brings forth.

Marina Modi
Juba, February 2026

The Evolution of Media in South Sudan: From Traditional Oral Storytelling to Modern Digital Platforms

by Mary Kadi Manoah

Introduction

Discussing media in South Sudan involves navigating a complex landscape of silence and expression, survival and innovation. Many, including myself, first experienced news indirectly through foreign outlets. Later, we returned to witness the delicate growth of local media systems. This evolution is personal as well as national, moving from fireside stories to Facebook feeds.

The principles of media community engagement, storytelling as information, and communication across distances have shaped South Sudan's communication landscape for generations. These principles echo through the rise of newspapers, the immediacy of radio, and the interactivity of digital platforms. The rhythm of voices around the fire lives on in the hum of a radio broadcast, the ping of WhatsApp, and even the brevity of a TikTok clip, reminding us that while the tools have changed, the human need to connect and share stories remains constant.

alive. Oral storytelling conveyed important information, like warnings about rebel movements, social events or metaphors about death and rebirth, such as "He has returned to earth" to signal death or "The lion has passed," to signal danger has passed. This tradition ensured survival when no formal media existed.

Tribal clans shared facts, memories and information around the fire or during community meetings, where voices created images that built identity and continuity. Oral storytelling served multiple roles. It was a tool for survival, ensuring critical information reached those in danger. It was also a means of preserving culture and collective memory, passing down tribal histories, social norms, and moral lessons from one generation to the next. Authority rested in the storyteller, whose voice carried credibility and command. In my rain-making clan, elders told us stories of divine wedding gifts of rain, which were represented by pellets. The fire crackled, sparks flew, and it became one of my fondest memories. Oral traditions created a sense of community and authority.

Oral Storytelling: The First Medium

For many, storytelling was the first medium, where news traveled by word of mouth. It was encoded in riddles, proverbs, and communal gatherings. Messages spread like in a game of "broken telephone." The accuracy was often unreliable, but the urgency kept stories

Print and Broadcast Media

Over time, newspapers appeared but remained elitist and fragile. They were accessible only to the literate, posing risks for those who read, translated, or shared their contents. During the CPA era and after independence, newspapers like Nile



Mirror, The Citizen, and Juba Monitor briefly thrived but struggled due to financial and political pressures.

Radio, however, became the heart of the nation. Men cycled with radios on their shoulders or hung them over bamboo fences while brushing their teeth to stay informed. Diaspora families tuned into BBC and Voice of America, as radio connected daily decisions with distant communities.

For South Sudanese abroad, the evolution of radio symbolized survival and nation-building. The launch of Sudan Radio Service (SRS) in 2003 marked a critical point, later becoming Eye Radio after independence. Eye Radio, established as a domestic voice for the newly independent nation, exemplifies the shift from passive reception to independent production, giving citizens information in local languages and on local issues. Exiled stations like Radio Tamazuj persist, serving diaspora and local audiences while navigating censorship.

Some commercial entertainment stations also appeared, but many struggle to survive due to limited advertising and tough operating conditions. Commercial radio stations emerged, offering information and entertainment that acted as therapy for trauma. Other church-owned and run stations also co-existed offering community programming, while commercial stations such as those focused on entertainment, many struggled financially. Many private ventures briefly launched and then disappeared, reflecting the sector's fragility.

Alongside the mainstream and commercial stations, a few niche and hybrid radio stations quietly shape South Sudan's media landscape. Advance Youth Radio,

for example, gives young people a space to talk about their lives, social issues, and community concerns. Meanwhile, UN Radio Miraya reaches communities across the country with news, public service announcements, and programs aimed at peacebuilding. Though few in number, these stations show how specialized and hybrid broadcasting can complement the larger media scene, giving citizens information, guidance, and a voice when it matters most.

Television has been the most vulnerable medium. During the 2011 referendum, state-run SSTV (turned SSBC) was the only broadcaster, crucial for sharing official updates. Later, private channels like Citizen TV, Africa 360, and Ebony TV briefly emerged but failed due to financial issues, censorship, and lack of infrastructure. Even regional outlets like Equator Broadcasting Corporation (EBC) experienced long periods of silence. Today, SSBC remains the main state channel, though it often struggles with consistency.

Today the main state channel, alongside newer private and digital-oriented stations like Junobna TV, Juba Echo TV offer a mix of news, entertainment, and youth-focused content. Despite these additions, television remains limited in reach, hindered by unreliable electricity, scarce equipment, and low audience penetration outside Juba. The evolution of TV in South Sudan reflects a persistent struggle between emergence and collapse, demonstrating both the medium's potential to inform and unite, and the obstacles that continue to challenge its sustainability.

Media Development

South Sudan's media sector has received considerable external support. USAID, the largest donor, along with other organizations, has played a critical role in developing media in the country by funding radio stations, building infrastructure, and improving professional skills through institutes, certificate programs, and internships. This support fostered a new generation of media practitioners and created a relatively vibrant ecosystem after the CPA. However, as international funding has decreased, especially following the reduction of USAID support, the sector now faces significant challenges. Outlets that thrived on donor projects struggle with financial stability, leading to closures, layoffs, and reduced programming. Coupled with political interference, weak advertising markets, and poor infrastructure, the loss of donor support has left South Sudan's media increasingly fragile.

The Internet Revolution and Social Media

The digital shift changed media consumption. Laptops, emails, and later smartphones brought immediacy to information sharing. Phone ownership skyrocketed, and platforms like Facebook and WhatsApp became vital for communication, even among government officials. Digital-native outlets like Hot in Juba and Eye Media reflect the demand for local news that global outlets often overlook. Social media has redefined how people verify, connect, and express themselves in a generation that navigates war and modernity.

Media in South Sudan is both fragile and essential. Whether around the fire, on the radio, or through WhatsApp groups, it remains a means for discussion, survival, and a tenuous sense of national identity. Podcasts are emerging as a new platform, offering niche, on-demand content with lower costs than FM radio. Though still developing, they are beginning to complement traditional and commercial radio, creating a hybrid audio landscape that mixes old and new media forms. Future trends suggest increased internet access, as seen in the rapid rise of platforms like TikTok, Facebook, and X (formerly Twitter), which are changing how younger audiences engage with and share content. The growth of social media, alongside the enduring role of radio, is fostering a hybrid media culture where traditional and digital channels coexist to meet different needs.

Conclusion

Each media era reflects the country's struggle to preserve voice, identity, and connection amid conflict and political uncertainty. The swaying between survival and expression, donor-supported growth and systemic collapse, highlights how deeply intertwined media is with social cohesion, civic engagement, and nation-building. Even as some outlets falter under financial and political pressures, the enduring presence of niche, hybrid, and digital platforms demonstrates that the need for information, dialogue, and community remains unstoppable.

Looking forward, South Sudan's media landscape stands at a crossroads, where tradition and innovation coexist. Increased internet penetration, the rise of social media, and the emergence of podcasts

signal new ways for citizens, especially the youth, to participate, question, and create. Yet, these opportunities exist alongside persistent challenges: fragile infrastructure, political interference, and economic uncertainty. The story of the media in South Sudan invites reflection on how a society can preserve its voice and agency amid adversity, and on how each tweet, broadcast, or whispered tale carries the potential to shape the nation's collective memory.

Mary Kadi Manoah *is an emerging South Sudanese writer and communications professional whose work explores resilience, displacement and untold stories of women and girls. She was part of a prose writing workshop with FEMRITE - The Association of Ugandan Women Writers - which led to a published short story within an anthology of South Sudanese women stories. Currently, she writes and contributes to short stories on interconnected narratives centered on women's journeys through adventure, brokenness and survival. Beyond her literary pursuits, she continues to lead communications in international development, blending creativity and strategy to highlight lived experiences of communities often left unheard.*



“Every story I tell is a path to inform, inspire, and make a difference. This is what the media gives too.”

Shama Chol Nawela,
news anchor, South Sudan
Broadcasting Corporation
(SSBC)

“Combining self study with formal training helped me build a strong understanding of film making and technical camera work. Film is powerful- storytelling can educate, inspire thus helping to shape a better society.”



Martin Charles,
Filmmaker, Angel films 211

South Sudan Media at the Crossroads: Building a National Voice for Peace and Unity

by Ajak Deng Chiengkou

South Sudan is not short of stories. From cattle camps to market stalls, from fishing villages to returnee settlements, the people speak daily with wisdom shaped by history and hardship. What is missing is not what to say, but the means to say it clearly, to each other and to the world.

Since independence, journalism in Sudan and later South Sudan has walked a narrow and difficult path. In the 1970s, Radio Juba was meant to become a national voice, but poor investment left it weak. During the war, Radio SPLA broadcast revolutionary victories, but not the daily struggles of ordinary people. When peace came in 2005, new radios and websites appeared, yet most were political or opinion-based. Investigative journalism remained scarce. Today, in 2025, the situation has shifted again. Social media platforms fill the air with words, but they often carry rumour as much as fact. The country is flooded with speech, but not always with truth.

Media is not decoration. It is the foundation of nationhood. A country that cannot hear itself cannot govern itself. People who do not listen to one another cannot stand together. Across rural towns and displaced communities, citizens rely on songs, sermons and social media posts to connect. These moments show both the hunger for information and the failure of national institutions to provide it.

The South Sudan Broadcasting Corporation was entrusted to be more than a studio

in Juba. It was meant to be the ear and mouth of the nation. Yet most cannot hear it. The child in a remote county, the fisher by the Nile, the cattle keeper in the savannah, none of them can depend on SSBC. A broadcaster that speaks only to the capital is not a national broadcaster. Without a trusted national voice, others will define us. Without dialogue within, peace itself becomes fragile.

Across the world, nations have invested in public broadcasters to shape their own stories, both to themselves and to the outside world. The BBC in Britain, Al Jazeera in Qatar, CBC in Canada and ABC in Australia carry the burden of informing citizens and shaping national identity. They promote unity and guard their country's narrative from distortion. South Sudan, by contrast, faces a different reality. The country does not speak with one tongue. English and Arabic dominate in towns, yet the majority in villages speak local languages and dialects. National broadcasts in English or Arabic cannot reach them. Miscommunication grows, disinformation spreads faster, and division deepens (Freedom House, 2023).

The shadow of the twenty-one-year liberation war lingers, followed by the 2013 crisis and years of instability. A negative narrative has taken root, placing blame on the government or tribes, trading prejudice for truth. Without positive alternatives, such distorted stories risk becoming the representation of the people. Good media,



with a national agenda of peace and coexistence, is the only tool capable of shifting that balance. It can provide stories of hope, civic education and unity, binding people beyond tribe and region.

If television floats above the people, then radio must return to the ground. Radio waits for no electricity or subscription. A solar or wind-up set can speak to a cattle camp at dawn or a fishing village by night. It can announce rains, market prices or the need for vaccination. It can carry songs, stories and warnings before conflict spreads. In villages dependent on megaphones and towns served by community FM stations, radio remains not a relic but a lifeline (UNESCO, 2023).

South Sudanese citizens themselves have become reporters. A youth in a rural settlement can document a broken bridge. A mother can livestream floods that threaten her community. These images carry truth, but also risk. Without training and protection, citizen journalists can be misled, harassed or silenced. UN inquiries have documented intimidation, surveillance and censorship of journalists, creating a climate of fear (OHCHR, 2023). Yet the opportunity remains to strengthen citizen voices through training, mentorship and safe platforms.

The absence of accessible information creates dangerous gaps. Farmers in remote villages may hear national news only when a traveller brings newspapers. Young people in towns often rely on social media groups, many of which spread rumour instead of fact. In such an environment, misinformation thrives and trust collapses. UNESCO has warned that weak infrastructure and media blackouts threaten fragile democracies (UNESCO, 2023).

Media literacy is therefore essential. When conflict flares or a natural disaster strikes, rumours can spread quickly. Panic rises if people lack tools to question and verify. Teaching media literacy in schools, churches and youth centres is as important as teaching reading. In a society where rumours have sparked violence, the ability to listen wisely and question critically is a matter of national survival.

South Sudan must also avoid the mistakes of larger nations where media has been captured by tycoons and interest groups. In such places, lies and unsubstantiated narratives dominate national debate. A fragile state like South Sudan cannot afford to allow its media to be manipulated by private or political agendas. Instead, its diversity should be celebrated. Media can be the champion of inclusion, giving equal space to communities from across the Nile, Equatoria, Bahr el Ghazal and Upper Nile so that no voice is erased.

The challenges are real. Funding remains scarce, leaving many community radios unable to sustain themselves once donor support ends. Misuse and abuse of media platforms by politicians and elites undermine trust. The principle of “do no harm” must guide all practitioners, ensuring reporting does not inflame tensions or deepen divisions. Good media should enlighten and educate, not polarise. Civic education must be at the centre of broadcasting, helping citizens understand their rights, responsibilities and the institutions that serve them.

Sustainability is possible when entrepreneurship is encouraged. Media houses should diversify their income through advertising, local support and diaspora contributions. Training qualified journalists must be prioritised, not only

in Juba but across the states. Editors, producers and fact checkers are as vital as reporters. Partnerships with universities and the South Sudanese diaspora can fill the gap in skills and experience. Professional training also builds trust. A reporter who knows how to check sources, a producer who understands ethical standards, an editor who applies the principle of fairness. These skills do more than produce content; they strengthen democracy itself.

The future of media also lies in technology. Artificial intelligence can translate local languages, archive oral traditions and amplify diverse voices. But it can also be misused for propaganda and manipulation. South Sudan must embrace innovation with caution, ensuring it strengthens truth and authenticity rather than eroding them. This requires deliberate investment in digital infrastructure and in training young South Sudanese to manage these tools. Technology must serve the people, not control them.

South Sudan is rich in stories, yet much of its knowledge is undocumented. We are proud of our culture, yet much of it is fading. We have achieved independence, yet often remain strangers to one another. Media can help change this, not with slogans, but with a steady and truthful presence.

The final call must go to media owners and practitioners. You hold in your hands the power to shape how South Sudan is seen and how South Sudanese see themselves. The choice is between feeding the division or planting peace. The call of this generation is clear. Build a media that strengthens the fragile state, promotes unity in diversity and carries the theme of peace across every broadcast and

publication. If South Sudan is to stand as one nation, it must first learn to listen to itself. Media must begin that work, not tomorrow, but now.

Ajak Deng Chiengkou *is an award-winning South Sudanese - Australian broadcast journalist and cultural advocate. He has worked across broadcast, print and digital media, with experience in radio, digital media, civic education and community engagement in South Sudan and the diaspora. His work focuses on preserving indigenous knowledge, strengthening democratic institutions and using media as a tool for peacebuilding and national unity.*

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Sustainability in Media Entrepreneurship: Maneuvering the Economy in South Sudan

by Denis Logonyi

In South Sudan, a country under financial constraints and fragile press freedom, the mortality rate of media houses is higher than in any other African country. Survival of newsrooms barely dangles on sacrificial commitment, creativity, business expertise and editorial skills, with many struggling and others already closing down due to cuts in global funding. Out of over 100 media houses, only about 15 are still surviving in the country, creating an information gap. According to South Sudan Media Authority, several media houses had registered, and majority are none operational and the media regulatory body does not provide reasons for the shutdown.

However, we attempt to delve into the coping mechanisms, experiences, and lessons that media houses adapt to remain on focus despite the numerous challenges. As lack of funding, difficulties in news collection and dwindling access to public information remain significant a challenge, these factors also raise concerns and cause an information gap, where journalists operate at risk. Traditional revenue models for media sustainability have weakened from subscription services, adverts, and branded content. The burden to explore means to strengthen work and survive the turmoil, now rests upon each individual media house.

Emmanuel Monychol Akop, who returned from the diaspora, (Britain) with the aim of improving media conditions in South Sudan had a vision to bridge the information

gap. He focused on establishing a media house that would reflect the identity of South Sudanese people. He then started The Dawn Newspaper. An idea was born in 2013.

In pursuit of media independence, Mr. Monychol decided not to seek donor funding to avoid being tied down by their demands. The establishment of the newspaper not only created a media house but also provided employment opportunities and a platform for professional development.

After independence, the media fraternity was filled with expatriates, who, Monychol believed, did not capture the South Sudanese context in their news writing, hence missed the gist. He pursued a Master of Science in media management to enhance the development of the media house back home, over the years.

"Most of the media houses way back from 2005 were driven by donor support and what we call briefcase trainers as consultants to train our journalists," Monychol noted.

He argues that the idea of context was missing since the trainers in the early years provided good tools in the wrong context. "Media is about entertainment. You cannot entertain, educate, and inform someone you don't know and the language they don't understand," he stresses.

Despite registering some successes, Monychol outlines the challenges faced by the media in South Sudan. He warns that the media in the country is on the brink of collapse due to the fragile situation with the government.

Monychol notes a contextual clash between the institution and the government, saying it's one of the reasons partially contributing to the collapse of some of the media houses. In addition to that, professionalism has been compromised and that contributes to information gap. He says government officials are not readily providing essential information to the public, leading to a reliance on social media.

"We don't have access to information and when we don't have access to information we work on guess work when you guess work you end up getting arrested for guessing the work you go look for information, yet no body is willing to give you the information," Monychol expresses.

However, as the much-needed support is not forthcoming, the hope of a thriving media in the country is fading, Monychol who had been under detention for over six months, noted upon acquiring freedom.

Meanwhile, economic crises coupled with the rise of social media has further punched the media market in the country to a stagger. "Revenue from sales decreased, leading to an overwhelming printing debt accumulation of over \$100,000 owed to Universal Printers" he says, adding that the public have been aroused by emotions and nobody is buying the newspaper because of emerging dependence of social media content. "What the public gets is unfiltered information yet what we produce is filtered, balanced,

objective, analyzed and researched information which is printed. Something that you can quote in a book" Monychol explains.

Amidst the hardship, in 2024, The Dawn Newspaper won the Newspaper of the year award by chamber of commerce, which Monychol attributes to hard work and investment into human interest stories rather than relying on official press conferences and press releases. Monychol hopes the website he opened in the last two to three years ago will be commercialized and optimized so that it could generate some income.

Oyet Patrick, President of South Sudan Journalists Union and a founder of Juba Echo Television, says to withstand the crisis, he had anticipatedly conducted a sustainability survey before kicking off. The Juba Echo TV, which started as an idea, grew to become a promising media house, admired by many and offering employment opportunities to journalists in South Sudan.

Oyet, who had hoped to start as a newspaper, made a twist to television broadcasting after studying the challenges faced by various media houses. "We first opened the Juba Echo website in 2015, ran our website for about a year and had to close because of sustainability and of course it was not generating any money because I was busy with other ventures," the media entrepreneur narrates. As he approaches 20 years in the media industry, Mr. Oyet has made a name in reporting for local and international media agencies. He hopes to leave a legacy through an established media house that will tell the stories of South Sudanese people.

Despite challenges in operation and low subscription for the television, Oyet still has to pick some money from his pocket to sustain the media house which employs twenty two workers. "We started as a small team. In 2022 we decided to formalize the process because we were still doing a survey and we agreed to have an online TV finally," he recalls.

The Juba Echo TV mastermind argues that most media houses that closed down did not conduct feasibility studies, and the owners are not journalists but business personnel who wanted to make quick money. Oyet notes that online media publication comes with challenges because of the risk posed by hackers. He had a bitter experience of losing his Facebook page with over 35,000 followers which compelled him to make a fresh start.

Though Oyet blames the scenario on lack of skills by some of his employees, his resilience, connections and support, enables survival of the institution. The media mogul boasts of training his employees received from experts in the region and opportunities he secured abroad that developed his media house.

Being the only private and online Television station in South Sudan, Oyet says most people do not understand how the media operates; as such he can't make money to support sustainability. The TV can now be accessed on south one decoder, home TV which can be watched all over the world.

"We found out that we are lacking the online TV and that's why we chose to be there since we only had SSBC TV. We now run 24/7 operations which require money, and it's a learning process, you have to work long hours to survive. It's challenging

but we have to go," Oyet laments. He advises owners of media houses to set aside different ventures to sustain the industry in the country if they are to have a flourishing media house that can be seen as an example. To Oyet, Media business does not remit profit immediately, so, one has to keep injecting money till time comes for it to be able to return profits because advertisement can't sustain any business. He also outlined that the presence of conflict in the country is one of the factors that has contributed to closure of some media houses away from those surviving on funding.

As tough times continue dragging on, the media industry, for **Mathiang Cirilo**, the managing director for the Almaugif newspaper, also echoes a similar scary atmosphere when it comes to sustainability. When South Sudan became a nation, Cirilo sought to provide information to the Arabic audience. The newspaper, an extension of the country's first Arabic-language newspaper, "Al-Masir," was first published in 2011 but in 2014, it ceased publication as a result of the decision to dissolve the partnership.

The newspaper was founded by a group of four journalists who had previously worked in Sudan years before the country's independence. They had to pool their financial resources to contribute to the establishment of the newspaper.

Cirilo says they adopted an editorial approach based on professionalism and expertise to be inclusive and a platform for everyone, reflecting their opinions. This versatility made the newspaper a destination for everyone, contributing to its development and empowerment in terms of the opinions and issues raised,

but they ran into issues with government officials.

He adds that despite having a brawl with some government officials who filed cases against the newspaper due to its publications, they still won because of their professionalism, which helped them make sales that sustained the newspaper. "We printed 3,000 copies daily, except for Sundays, when sales outlets sold out before midday; I believe the favorable economic conditions at that time also contributed to the newspaper's widespread circulation." He attributes difficulties encountered in the past to the political environment at that time, along with the media laws, which, after their passage, saw improvements.

However, with the continuous crisis following the 2017 conflict, Cirilo notices that the general political and economic impasse greatly affects print media industry. "Now, the major challenge is the difficult economic situation, the migration of distinguished journalists to other fields in search of a better living, and the failure of the democratic transition in the country. Independent journalism cannot develop under the current political situation."

The newspaper now prints three days a week and other days online in order to keep the media house moving and to serve the Arabic readership. He advises that for a media house to prosper, there must be a commitment to professionalism, financial and administrative transparency in media organizations, and the presence of business partners who believe that the purpose of establishing newspapers is not financial gain but rather contributing to building community awareness. "The goal is to keep pace so we don't find ourselves falling behind. Our fellows have responded

positively to this shift, and it has also enabled us to attract a new audience outside the country."

In order to catch up with technology, he is reporting a shift in an online presence and boasting about two million people visiting their page monthly, which he hopes will bring support to the growth of the newspaper. Also, to maintain balance, he adds that they are striving to maintain continuous printing so that they can generate advertising revenue to cover other administrative and financial obligations.

Adia Jildo is a South Sudanese journalist based in Juba with over seven years of professional experience in broadcast, print, and digital media. Adia is a versatile freelance contributor, and volunteer who has worked with multiple media houses, including Juba Echo TV, No.1 Citizen Daily Newspaper, Citizenship Daily (Nigeria), also served as Assignment Editor at Juba Echo TV. She also featured for International outlets such as Xinhua News Agency. She is also a two time award winner of two prestigious peace journalism from the Union of Journalists of South Sudan (UJOSS) and the Community Media Network South Sudan.



"Challenges such as limited resources and field risks continue to persist, though journalists must remain committed to bold, truthful journalism and unwavering commitment in order to craft powerful national narratives that spark conversation and change."

William Maduok,
Journalist

"Most people do not understand how the media operates; and it's a learning process, you have to work long hours to survive. It's challenging but we have to go. We now run 24/7 operations which require money, I cannot make money to support sustainability."



Oyet Patrick Charles,
Founder Juba Echo TV

created by
AI



Access to Information: Communities Navigating the Blind Spots

by Chol Makol Riak

Access to credible information is the heartbeat of community development. In South Sudan, however, media and telecommunications infrastructure remains tethered to major urban hubs, creating a digital and informational divide. This concentration leaves much of the country in 'blind spots,' where unreliable networks, radio frequency radius limitations, and inaccessible infrastructures to access satellite internet render conventional information sources unreachable.

For communities operating within these gaps, the search for truth requires more than just modern technology—it demands local ingenuity. Here, we explore how one community is defying these constraints to keep vital information flowing.

In many rural villages of Jonglei State, the sound of a megaphone still marks the arrival of news. With no reliable radio signal, no phone networks, and no internet connectivity, communities depend on word of mouth, community criers, and notice boards to stay informed. For residents like 45-year-old farmer Ayuen Manyang, this system feels like “living in the dark.” “If there is sickness, fighting, or even government information, we only know when someone walks here to tell us,” Ayuen explained. “Sometimes the message comes too late.”

The lack of access to reliable communication channels has become one

of the most pressing challenges in rural South Sudan, affecting everything from health services to peacebuilding.

Community Radios Under Strain

Local community radio stations—Radio Jonglei FM, Voice of Reconciliation, and Peace FM—are often the only professional information outlets attempting to bridge the gap. But their coverage is limited. Peter Kuol Kuch, station manager at Radio Voice of Reconciliation FM, said technical and financial constraints make it nearly impossible to reach remote areas. “Our broadcast strength cannot go beyond a certain radius,” Kuol noted. “Villages outside Bor or Twic East are cut off. We also face frequent power shortages, which reduces airtime.” He added.

He said some prioritise megaphone in informing the community within Bor town but as the media professionals in Jonglei state, they discourage such practices. “What is being practiced here in Bor is sometimes not understandable, it was during the liberation where this means of communication was used but we thought it could be changed because we have got many radio stations within Bor here maybe from far northern Jonglei” said Peter. Peace FM in Akobo faces similar problems, due to rugged terrain, insecurity, and lack of maintenance for on ground transmitters.

Local Chiefs as Gatekeepers

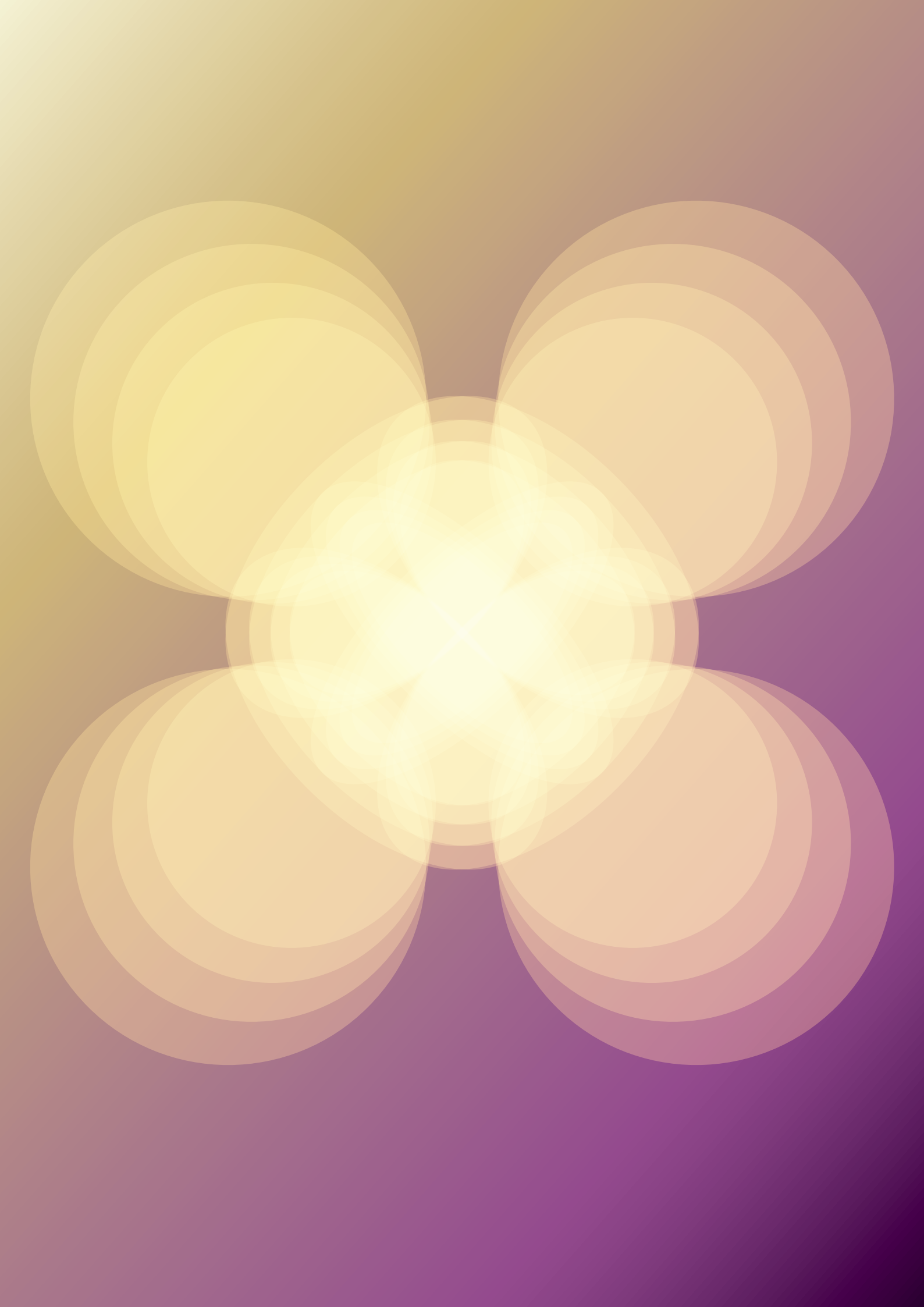
In the absence of reliable networks, local chiefs and administrative leaders serve as the de facto gatekeepers of information. Chief Ayuen Manyang of the Angakuei community said he spends hours relaying government notices and NGO announcements from one village to another. “People look to us for guidance, but it is a heavy burden,” Manyang said. “We use megaphones or community gatherings, but in emergencies, this is too slow.” He added.

The consequences are particularly stark during health crises. The Jonglei State Ministry of Health (JSMoH) confirmed that delayed communication has undermined responses to outbreaks such as measles and cholera. Dr. Bol Chau Mayol, a medic director at Jonglei state hospital, said lives have been lost due to information delays. “If people don’t hear radio alerts or phone messages in time, they miss vaccinations, or they continue unsafe practices,” Dr. Bol explained. “This is not just an inconvenience; it costs lives.”

Experts Call for Technical Solutions

Telecommunications experts argue that low-cost solutions exist but require investment and policy support. Bol Mayar, a broadcasting specialist in Bor, said solar-powered transmitters, community relay points, and partnerships with mobile operators could expand coverage significantly. “We don’t need big infrastructure everywhere; simple relay stations can extend radio signals and allow life-saving information to reach the last mile.” Said Bol.

South Sudan’s information blind spots are more than a technical issue-they shape how communities understand governance, security, and development. Without reliable communication, rumors spread faster than facts, undermining trust in institutions. Individuals stepping in though not equipped to the best, support these structures but this is also just a temporary fix.



Beyond Journalism: The Creative Media Identity

by Marina Modi



The media is a massive umbrella, yet in South Sudan, anyone holding a camera is instantly categorized under a single bracket. "When people see me with my camera, I often get asked which media house I work for," says Samuel Kuol. "But I tell them I belong to no media house." This common misidentification highlights a significant hurdle for modern visual creators in Juba: public perception.

There is a distinct difference between news media and creative media. While mainstream and citizen journalists focus on information delivery, creative media leverages artistic, technological, and storytelling skills to produce visually and audibly compelling content. Photographers, filmmakers, animators, and graphic designers might use the same tools as journalists, but they operate in an entirely different sphere. Understanding and differentiating these roles not only delinks

Samuel Kuol is the founder of Mahandis Studio along Gudele Road. But to his peers and mentees, he is the Creative Baba aka the motivated- a title earned through over a decade of relentless execution across music, photography, and videography. More than just a marker of personal style, "Baba" signifies a father figure. Samuel has spent more than ten years not just practicing his craft, but actively nurturing the next generation of talent, some of whom now head creative operations in

major government offices.

Where access to quality formal technical media skill training is often limited, Samuel believes passion is king. These mentorship and self driven passion schools are a true bridge to nurturing a future for creative media practitioners. "With passion people can learn even from platforms like TikTok and YouTube, they host a wealth of tutorials. If the passion is there, the resources are infinite."

Like many creatives, Samuel's journey wasn't a straight line. Forced to study Logistics and procurement, the true calling lay elsewhere. The spark was ignited early on by an uncle who worked as a photographer in Narus, and later by an elder brother who introduced the craft of drawing. That early exposure blossomed into an unyielding passion. During high school, it meant sneaking out just to practice.

A Future to look forward to

Looking at the trajectory of his own growth, Samuel believes the South Sudan creative media industry is rapidly accelerating. He started out with just a laptop doing basic graphic design at a time when only a handful of people were in the field. From there, he expanded into photography, eventually scaling up to a fully-equipped professional studio. Today, he looks out at a booming market teeming

with fresh, young talent. If this much growth can happen in less than a decade, the next few years promise to completely transform the landscape.

“The future is incredibly bright. However, to truly unlock its potential, South Sudan’s creative media sector needs a unifying body- an association to bring practitioners together, protect their interests, and pave a structured path forward for the many raw talents still waiting to be nurtured” Samuel says.

Until then, the standard question of misidentification will remain. But for Samuel and the growing league of creative media practitioners the answer will stay firm and clear: “I am a creator, not a journalist.”

Marina Modi *is a media consultant working at the intersection of Media,tech and social transformation. Working solutions addressing gaps in the sector from research, innovations, productions to trainings and generally documenting the evolution of the South Sudan media ecosystem.*



“With passion people can learn even from platforms like TikTok and YouTube, they host a wealth of tutorials. If the passion is there, the resources are infinite.”

Samuel Kuolo,
founder of Mahandis Studio



“I have used the media to safeguard tangible cultural heritage and connect ancestral identities across communities.”

Jackie Ben,
Programmes Officer,
Ma'Mara Sakit Village

The Role of Citizen Journalism in South Sudan: How Ordinary People Are Shaping the Narrative

by Mawa Minga



In South Sudan, where professional media often faces constraints like limited resources, political pressure, insecurity, and infrastructural challenges, ordinary citizens are increasingly taking the reins of information dissemination. Armed with smartphones, social media accounts, and community networks, these citizen journalists are not only reporting events as they unfold but are actively shaping public debate, challenging misinformation, and fostering accountability. From social media pages run by young South Sudanese in Juba and rural towns, to diaspora-based platforms connecting communities across continents, citizen journalism is transforming the country's media landscape.

I have had discussions with different people from different backgrounds and different walks of life, professional journalist, social media page admins, content creators, and ordinary citizens who are using social media to raise awareness or run campaigns about issues or topics that they find important or beneficial to flip the current perspective about South Sudan that is scattered all across media outlets all over the world, or ordinary citizens that are using social media to speak to their peers or communities about issues that they can all relate to. Some of them are compiled and summarized as follows:

The Rise of Citizen Journalism

For many ordinary South Sudanese, citizen journalism began as a simple act of sharing information. Fred Lomoro Charles Minga, an aviator and licensed flight dispatcher, explains: "Any ordinary citizen has the right to use digital tools to report and share information based on their knowledge and the issues they care about." Lomoro cites examples like recording videos of traffic officers in disputes with road users or documenting heavy rains blocking roads. Some citizens even conduct small investigations, analyze information, and present it in ways that their communities can easily understand.

The platforms of choice are typically Facebook, TikTok, and WhatsApp, though each has its unique strengths and limitations. Lomoro notes that Facebook and TikTok allow him to reach a broad audience with recorded videos, while WhatsApp is limited to quick to pass stories. Importantly, Lomoro emphasizes that his work is not motivated by politics but by a desire to inform citizens of their rights. For instance, he launched awareness campaigns about the South Sudan Labor Act, highlighting abuses by foreign-dominated private sectors and educating ordinary citizens about defending their rights even without a lawyer.

Lomoro’s motivation reflects a broader pattern in South Sudan: many citizen journalists are driven by personal experience, activism, or distrust of mainstream media. Their reporting can be a mix of immediacy, authenticity, and occasional subjectivity, offering perspectives that traditional outlets sometimes cannot access. As Lomoro puts it: “Smart people learn through their mistakes, and wise people learn through others.” Citizen journalists are thus simultaneously participants in news creation and educators for their communities.

The Spectrum of Citizen Reporting

The content citizen journalists produce is diverse. Emmanuel Obeid Kundu, a data analyst and professional journalist with experience at BBC Media Action and Internews South Sudan, observes that citizen journalism is mostly complementary to professional media. In a country where rural areas and conflict zones are difficult for journalists to access, citizens provide timely, on-the-ground reporting. However, there are challenges: unverified content can be biased, one-sided, or emotionally driven, particularly in sensitive areas like conflict, gender issues, or communal disputes.

Anak Dut, a reporter at City Review Newspaper, elaborates that citizen content often serves as raw leads. Professional journalists cross-check these posts with multiple sources, verify facts through eyewitness accounts, and use tools such as reverse image searches or metadata analysis to confirm authenticity. Verified citizen-generated material can then enrich reporting by adding immediacy and local perspective. Dut cites the example of

conflict coverage in Lakes State, where citizen videos from Rumbek cattle camps allowed journalists to report incidents in real-time while adding context and analysis to produce credible and nuanced reports. Yet, the risks of misinformation are real. Viral falsehoods—from doctored images to misattributed videos—can spread rapidly on social media, shaping public perception before journalists have a chance to respond. Emmanuel Bida Thommas, founder and editor-in-chief of Clarity Desk, notes that false casualty figures, propaganda, and politically motivated narratives are among the most common forms of misinformation. Citizen journalists sometimes lack the tools or training to identify these red flags, leading to unintentional harm. For instance, in South Sudan, a viral video alleging the killing of South Sudanese in Sudan incited attacks on traders in Juba, demonstrating how misinformation can trigger real-world unrest.

Platforms and Vulnerabilities

Different social media platforms carry distinct risks. According to Mr. Thomas, WhatsApp is especially prone to spreading misinformation, due to its private, encrypted messaging groups. Facebook and TikTok also serve as major conduits for rumors, while platforms like Clubhouse are primarily used by diaspora communities to propagate opinions or narratives about local events. Amin Joseph, a South Sudanese creative designer and media professional based in Rwanda, also the founder of the Visit Wau Initiative, adds that Facebook remains the most effective platform for engagement, while TikTok offers potential for reaching younger audiences due to its viral algorithm. The speed of information is a double-edged

sword. While rapid reporting enables timely awareness, it also allows false stories to gain traction before verification. Corrections often fail to reach the same audience as the initial post, posing challenges for citizen journalists who seek to maintain credibility. Digital literacy emerges as a crucial factor: the ability to evaluate sources, detect manipulated content, and responsibly share information can determine whether citizen reporting informs or misleads.

Verification, Ethics, and Training

Professional journalists view verification and ethical standards as essential in bridging the gap between citizen reporting and reliable news. As Emmanuel Obeid Kundu emphasizes, citizen-generated content must be treated carefully, verifying locations, sources, and context, especially in politically sensitive or conflict-related stories. Fact-checking organizations, media literacy programs, and partnerships between professional and citizen journalists help strengthen the integrity of reporting. For instance, 211Check.org, Digitalized Frontlines, and the Excellence Foundation provide training, toolkits, and guidance for citizen journalists, promoting ethical reporting practices without stifling freedom of expression.

A common theme across citizen journalists is the need for responsibility and transparency. Samuel Dhuol Majur, manager of the Gok Media Facebook page, stresses the importance of cross-checking multiple sources, deleting errors promptly, and issuing public apologies when mistakes occur. Amin Joseph echoes this, noting that admitting mistakes and explaining corrections fosters long-term trust, even when misinformation spreads faster than verified facts.

However, there are limits. Citizen journalists often cannot be held to the same fact-checking standards as professionals, given the informal nature of their work, lack of regulatory oversight, and absence of centralized accountability. Training, mentorship, and voluntary codes of conduct are therefore emphasized as more practical solutions than strict enforcement.

Impacts on Communities and Policy

Citizen journalism in South Sudan has tangible effects. Lomoro describes how his posts about labor rights or corruption have prompted community discussions and raised awareness of legal protections. Emmanuel Obeid Kundu highlights cases where citizen reporting exposed misconduct by traffic officers or documented local conflicts, enabling professional media to deliver verified stories that catalyzed accountability. Conversely, misinformation can influence public opinion and policy negatively. Thommas cites viral rumors about government appointments leading to resignations or dismissals, demonstrating the power and risk of unverified citizen content.

Beyond news, citizen journalism shapes community identity and culture. Social media pages like those run by Amin Joseph and Samuel Majur highlight local heritage, youth initiatives, sports, and entertainment, fostering engagement and pride. They also provide platforms for marginalized voices who might otherwise be ignored by traditional media.

Citizen Journalism as a Complement, not a Replacement

Across all the interviews, a consensus emerges: citizen journalism is not a replacement for professional media but a vital complement. It offers immediacy, local knowledge, and diversity of perspective, while professional outlets provide verification, context, and ethical reporting standards. Collaborations between the two can produce stronger, more credible reporting that informs the public, holds authorities accountable, and mitigates misinformation.

As Anak Dut notes, professional journalists often use citizen reports as leads, combining them with field verification, interviews, and analysis to create comprehensive coverage. Similarly, citizen journalists benefit from guidance on accuracy, ethical considerations, and responsible reporting, which enhances their credibility and impact.

Challenges and Opportunities

Despite its promise, citizen journalism faces persistent challenges:

- Misinformation and rumors: Viral false content can incite violence or erode public trust.
- Limited digital literacy: Both creators and consumers of content need skills to evaluate information.
- Resource constraints: Fact-checking and verification require time and networks that ordinary citizens may lack.
- Platform dynamics: Algorithms prioritize engagement over accuracy, amplifying sensational content.

Opportunities, however, abound:

- Capacity-building initiatives: Workshops, fellowships, and online resources can equip citizen journalists with verification skills.
- Partnerships: Collaboration with professional journalists and fact-checking organizations strengthens accountability.
- Digital literacy campaigns: Educating audiences reduces the likelihood of misinformation being shared or believed.
- Community storytelling: Citizen media can highlight local culture, youth initiatives, and social issues often overlooked by mainstream outlets.

Voices from the Frontlines

From Lomoro’s labor rights campaigns to Amin Joseph’s multimedia storytelling and Samuel Majur’s Gok Media updates, citizen journalists are proving that ordinary South Sudanese can shape public narratives, educate communities, and even influence policy. Even when mistakes occur, transparency and accountability help build trust with audiences. The rise of social media pages run by young people in Juba, rural towns, and diaspora communities highlights a vibrant ecosystem that blends entertainment, information, and activism.

As one anonymous media admin in Melbourne observes, the shift from traditional news to creative, viral content can still impact public opinion, showing that citizen journalism is both powerful and nuanced. It reflects the creativity, resilience, and agency of South Sudanese citizens in a media landscape that is evolving rapidly.

Conclusion

Citizen journalism in South Sudan is reshaping the country’s information ecosystem. By providing immediacy, authenticity, and local perspectives, ordinary citizens complement professional journalism, highlight community issues, and hold authorities accountable. Yet, this new media frontier carries risks from misinformation to ethical dilemmas that require digital literacy, verification, and responsible practices.

Ultimately, the growth of citizen journalism reflects the desire of ordinary South Sudanese to claim their voice in the public sphere, educate peers, and influence positive change. While challenges remain, collaborations between professional journalists, fact-checking organizations, and citizen reporters promise a media landscape that is more inclusive, resilient, and reflective of the lived experiences of the people it serves. In a country where mainstream media faces limitations, citizen journalists are not just observers, they are participants shaping the narrative, one post, video, and story at a time.

Mawa Minga *is a multi-talented professional with a diverse background as a Writer, Poet, and Musician. A dedicated media professional with experience in journalism, public communication, and storytelling. Passionate about shaping narratives and amplifying voices, he works across traditional and digital platforms to inform, engage, and inspire communities. With a strong background in citizen journalism, event hosting, and content creation, Mawa brings both creativity and credibility to the media space.*

Promoting Media Literacy in South Sudan: Closing the Gap Through Education and Action

by Adia Jildo

Introduction

For years, South Sudan has fought low literacy rates but still records significantly low percentages. According to a UNESCO report, South Sudan has one of the lowest literacy rates in the world and the region- with 30% of the population can read and write, with youth literacy at 54%. Many struggle to distinguish fact from falsehood, despite high rates of media consumption. Literacy -the ability to read, write, and understand and constructively put to utilisation is not only a basic human right but also a cornerstone of socio-economic development and informed citizenship. Media practice has picked up but is heavily scrutinized by the public- challenged by independent new media practitioners outside of the normal. This reality leaves communities grappling with what information is trustworthy and safe to consume.

Manifestations- of Media Information literacy realities in South Sudan

One of the major manifestations is observed in the rates of mis/disinformation and hate speech patterns, struggle to identify trusted sources of information thus making many vulnerable- highly susceptible to rumors and misinformation. Limited Infrastructure hindering access to

information, trust in media, Poor Digital hygiene with many unaware of online safety practices and struggle to use digital platforms critically. vulnerability to online scams and the consumption of harmful content. Limited language use in outlets limit access to those unable to read and write the official and national languages read and write in English or Arabic, respectively.

Community Perspective

"It is very difficult for us to say a specific source of information like radio or social media is the right source of media that we should trust. Despite the fact that we have radios in South Sudan, we cannot say the media is independent because of where they get their sources of income," said Joyce, a student.

Deng Nhial Chioh explained: "The issue of sharing and getting information is very inadequate, the statistics talk for itself. We need to focus on education, national language. There is a need for the education of one to write and learn their national language. This is important. According to Nhial, there is a need for the Ministry of Education to integrate national languages into the curriculum enabling smooth learning and information sharing."



created by
AI

Joyce Bako, a student at the University of Juba, said she understood media literacy only at a minimal level, seeing it as a way of sharing information for public consumption. However, she added, “Media is broad, though I can never trust any media, not even radios.”

Efforts to Address and the rise of fact checking

Several locally founded initiatives stepped up to help address the literacy gaps from a local context best understood by the locals. Addressing elements from health to peace and security along with cultural elements depending on prevailing triggers. According to 211Check data, the literacy gaps were mostly experienced in scenarios like; there were a lot of pages that were also giving false information and everyone was sharing it, when we shared the right, shared right information, people had to retract from that.

211 Check started as a COVID-19 response quickly grew into a youth-driven movement against misinformation, disinformation, and hate speech in South Sudan. But the issues started way before this. Every morning, Ochaya James, a fact checker at 211 Check, scans WhatsApp groups and flagged social media posts. The team looked for “red flags”—content designed to provoke fear, anger, or outrage. “The challenge is finding evidence to counter some claims is very hard, which makes it difficult to debunk, especially on political propaganda,” Ochaya explained.

To verify, they break content into claims, analyze the credibility of sources, and cross-check with reputable outlets. For images and videos, they turn to tools like Google Reverse Image Search and TinEye.

Once verified, their findings are published online, pushing back against falsehoods before they spiral out of control.

Misinformation in South Sudan did not end with the pandemic. As the country moves toward greater decentralisation, fake news surrounding politics, security, and tribal conflict spreads rapidly-threatening fragile peace-building efforts. Youth, who form the majority of the population, stand at the centre of this digital battlefield. As tech-savvy bloggers, podcasters, and social media users, they are both vulnerable to false information and uniquely positioned to counter it.

In a country where misinformation once spread unchecked, a generation of young fact-checkers is proving that truth-localized, verified, and shared-can be one of the strongest tools for peace. Initiatives such as Clarity Desk, Crystal media Hub and other news rooms initiating their fact checking desk, accurate, balanced information can be shared to the public.

Actions for the better

Addressing information and media literacy (MIL) in South Sudan is a complex and long-term endeavor that requires a multi-faceted approach. Given the country's unique challenges, including low literacy rates, limited infrastructure, and a history of conflict, strategies must be tailored to these specific circumstances. While some efforts are already underway, more can be done by learning from successful initiatives in neighboring countries and around the world.

Current Actions and Strategies in South Sudan include established MIL centers, such as the one at Juba Day Secondary

School- providing students with access to computers and the internet, offering hands-on training in digital literacy, media skills, and critical thinking. Equipping young people with the tools to navigate a media-saturated world responsibly and to become informed citizens.

Also Media advocacy organisations conduct capacity building for stakeholders on ethical reporting, conflict-sensitive journalism, and fact-checking-crucial for improving the quality of news and combating misinformation at its source. Community-Based and centered Initiatives designing programs to promote critical thinking while providing platforms for local dialogue. Continuing to raise awareness, evaluate and readjust for community effectiveness. The #defyhatenow campaign, think b4uclick, hagiga wahid have worked to address online and offline information disorders.

Still more more to be done

To push beyond the present, we need to embrace more actions at various levels. For instance stakeholders Integrating MIL into the National Curriculum for students, expanding Community Radio Reach and Content- Expanding radio coverage to remote areas and designing specific radio shows in local languages, and further picking some good lessons from other countries that can be applicable to the local context. This is a work in progress and all hands needed on deck.

Adia Jildo is a South Sudanese journalist based in Juba with over seven years of professional experience in broadcast, print, and digital media. Adia is a versatile freelance contributor, and volunteer who has worked with multiple media houses, including Juba Echo TV, No.1 Citizen Daily Newspaper, Citizenship Daily (Nigeria), also served as Assignment Editor at Juba Echo TV. She also featured for International outlets such as Xinhua News Agency. She is also a two time award winner of two prestigious peace journalism from the Union of Journalists of South Sudan (UJOSS) and the Community Media Network South Sudan.



“While opportunities for learning still lag behind, the industry has at least created a space for people like me to learn, grow, and hope for a better future in media.”

Emmanuela William, Intern,
South Sudan Broadcasting
Corporation (SSBC)



Closing Remark: AI and the Hybrid Future Storytelling

by Marina Modi

The rapid integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) into media and creative sectors has triggered a divide between skepticism regarding ethical pitfalls and optimism about its transformative potential. I took on a practical editorial experiment exploring how AI functions as an assistive tool for production and storytelling, highlighting both its current limitations and its capacity to act as a powerful equalizer. Looking at the needs of this publication, the editorial desk did a practical test to ascertain how these kinds of assistive technologies could support production and storytelling in this context. The experiments stretched the potentials of various highly spoken AI capabilities to check effectiveness and weigh in on what the future holds for storytelling generally.

Practical Realities and Limitations

The experiment affirmed that while AI can support storytelling, it remains dependent on human oversight. Key findings from the editorial desk include:

- The workflow is Human-Centric serving a supporting role. Concepts must be human-conceived and prompted, and results require manual evaluation and editing to ensure narrative cohesion.
- Technical Hurdles: We encountered some algorithmic bias in human skintone and perception biases, misinterpretation of prompts, and on some accounts hallucinations after repeated tasks.

Generating consistent visuals remains complex, and correcting errors can be time-consuming, sometimes requiring extensive negotiation with the software.

- Visual Consistency is best achieved with a single AI platform than checking across multiple platforms and even so, refreshing commands once in a while to limit AI fatigue and confusion.
- Research Risks: AI engines often lack real-time or localized data, posing a significant risk of misinformation for users who cannot independently verify the output.
- Quality Control: AI disclaimers are not mere text but rather mean what they say. It is paramount for the prompt engineer to pay attention, as the technology is prone to errors

Opportunities for Growth

Despite these hurdles, AI offers immense potential to overcome infrastructural deficits, particularly in contexts like South Sudan:

- Democratization of Tools: By reducing the need for expensive software licenses and high-end computing labs, AI lowers the entry cost for creative production. Strong internet and prompt engineering become the primary prerequisites.
- Upscaling Local Content: AI empowers grassroots journalists by cleaning audio, sharpening low-quality images, and

formatting data to meet international standards.

- Efficiency in Creation: Complex tasks, such as rendering animations or data graphics, which previously required teams of specialists, can now be achieved by individual creators using AI co-pilots.
- Cultural Preservation: AI provides a digital canvas for filmmakers and writers to storyboard and script oral histories, helping to preserve local heritage in vivid, accessible formats.

A Hybrid Future

The debate surrounding AI-whether it will replace jobs or enhance capabilities-is complex. The conclusion of this study suggests a "yes and no" reality: while AI displaces some traditional labor, it creates new possibilities by expanding what a single creator can produce. Ultimately, the future of media, particularly in developing landscapes, is hybrid. While ethical caution is necessary, the industry cannot afford to ignore technology that offers a path to bypass infrastructural limitations.

By positioning AI as a tool for amplifying and enhancing human creativity- as seen in the successful upscaling of work from local photojournalists- the sector can leverage these advancements to meet global standards while maintaining authentic, localized storytelling. The media practitioner equipped with quality AI prompting skills is the best prepared for the future.

Imprint



Published 2026 by #ASKnet
The Access to Skills & Knowledge network
www.asknet.community

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Pictures: ????

#ASKnet 2022-2025 is funded by the German Ministry for Economic
Development and Cooperation (BMZ).

